

A TRAVEL GUIDE FOR OUR INTERNATIONAL GUESTS

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"Everything you need to know to come celebrate with us"

Ceremony — Parroquia Santa Bibiana, 3:30 p.m.

Reception — Centro Italiano di Bogotá, 5:30 p.m.

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 28TH

Welcome to Colombia!

We're so happy that you've decided to cross borders (and sometimes oceans!) to be with us on one of the most important days of our lives. We know traveling to a new country can raise a lot of questions, so we put together this guide with everything we thought could help — from Bogotá's weather to our favorite spots around the whole country, in case you'd like to use the trip as a chance to get to know Colombia a little better.

This guide is a collection of personal, trusted recommendations — not bookings or commitments on our part. Please confirm any rates or availability directly when you book.

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One tip before you dive in: Colombia is a big, diverse country — in a single one-hour flight you can go from Bogotá's 14°C (57°F) to the Caribbean coast's 30°C (86°F). If you're planning to combine the wedding with other destinations, keep that in mind while packing.

A little bit about Colombia

Some quick facts before you land

Colombia sits in the northwest corner of South America and is the only country on the continent with coastlines on both the Pacific Ocean and the Caribbean Sea. It's a country of extremes packed close together: snow-capped Andean peaks, Amazon rainforest, Caribbean beaches, and coffee hills, often just a short flight apart.

~53M

people, the 3rd most populous country in South America

32

departments (states), each with its own traditions and cuisine

1,900+

bird species — more than any other country on Earth

Language & people

The official language is **Spanish**, spoken with a wide range of regional accents — Bogotá's is famously clear and easy to understand, while the Caribbean coast speaks faster and drops a lot of consonants. Beyond Spanish, more than 65 indigenous languages are still spoken across the country, along with Creole languages like Palenquero and San Andrés/Providencia's English-based Creole.

A (very) short history

Long before European contact, the territory now known as Colombia was home to indigenous civilizations such as the Muisca (around present-day Bogotá) and the Tayrona (around Santa Marta), known for their goldwork and engineering. The Spanish arrived in the early 1500s, and the region remained a Spanish colony — first as part of the Viceroyalty of New Granada — for roughly 300 years.

Independence was won in the early 1800s, led in large part by **Simón Bolívar**, and Colombia briefly formed "Gran Colombia" together with what are now Venezuela, Ecuador, and Panama, before each went its own way. Today Colombia is a democratic republic, and its recent history has also been one of remarkable transformation — cities like Medellín and Bogotá have undergone extraordinary change in the last two decades and are now among the region's most dynamic and creative hubs.

A few fun facts

- Colombia is the world's **second-largest coffee producer** (after Brazil) — and one of the very few countries that grows coffee year-round.
- It's considered the **second most biodiverse country on Earth**, despite being far smaller than countries like Brazil or Indonesia.
- The legend of **El Dorado**, the mythical city of gold, comes from Colombia — tied to Muisca rituals at Laguna de Guatavita, near Bogotá.
- Colombia is the birthplace of Nobel laureate **Gabriel García Márquez** and the literary style known as magical realism.
- It's one of the world's top producers of **cut flowers** and fine **emeralds**.
- Cali is widely considered the **world capital of salsa**, while the Caribbean coast is the birthplace of cumbia and vallenato.

Good to know: Colombians are famously warm and welcoming — don't be surprised if people go out of their way to help you, especially once they hear you've come from abroad for a wedding!

General travel tips

Everything to keep in mind when traveling to Colombia

Bogotá's weather

Bogotá sits at 2,640 meters (8,660 ft) above sea level, so the climate is cool year-round — there aren't clearly marked seasons like in the northern hemisphere, just a fairly stable climate with rain that can show up any time of year. Temperatures range roughly between 8°C and 19°C (46°F–66°F), averaging around 14°C (57°F).

- **Pack in layers:** a light shirt or blouse, a sweater or cardigan, and a jacket or coat for the evenings and rain.
- **Bring something waterproof** (a small umbrella or a jacket with a hood): it can rain suddenly at any time of year.
- The sun in Bogotá is stronger than it feels because of the altitude, so sunscreen is a good idea even on cloudy days.
- For the wedding day: the ceremony is at 3:30 p.m. indoors, but for the evening reception we'd recommend keeping a jacket, shawl, or light coat handy — it cools down noticeably after 7 p.m.

Documents & entering the country

- **Valid passport**, with at least 6 months of validity from the date of entry.
- **Visa:** most nationalities (United States, Canada, the United Kingdom, the European Union, and many more) **do not need a visa** to enter as tourists for up to 90 days. If you're unsure about your specific nationality, check the official *Migración Colombia* website before booking flights.
- **Vaccines:** no vaccination certificate is required to enter Colombia. The one exception is yellow fever, required only for travelers arriving from certain at-risk countries (unlikely to apply to most guests) — but if you're planning to visit the Amazon after the wedding, it's a good idea to get vaccinated at least 10 days beforehand.
- **Travel insurance:** not mandatory, but we always recommend it, especially if you'll be doing outdoor activities in other regions.

Money & payments

- The currency is the **Colombian peso (COP)**. International credit/debit cards are widely accepted in Bogotá, Cartagena, and Medellín; in more remote areas (Amazonas, small towns) it's best to carry cash.
- Our recommendation: **bring US dollars and exchange them** once you're here — you'll typically get a better rate than exchanging before you leave home. You can change dollars or euros at banks, exchange houses, or the airport. Most businesses don't accept direct payment in dollars.
- If you'd rather go digital, apps like **Global 66 and Littio** work great for holding and converting money electronically, and are a solid alternative to carrying cash around.
- For getting around the city, apps like **Uber, inDrive, or Cabify** work great and are the safest, most convenient way to travel.

Power outlets: 110V, type A/B plugs (same as the United States). If you're coming from Europe or the UK, you'll need an adapter.

Language: Spanish. Outside of hotels and tourist areas, English isn't that common — a translation app always helps.

Getting around & safety

Bogotá is a big city and traffic can be unpredictable, especially on Saturday afternoons — so if you're coming to the wedding, please plan to leave with extra time for both the church and the reception. Neither the Parroquia Santa Bibiana nor the Centro Italiano has ample parking, so your best bet is arriving by taxi or rideshare app. As in any big city, use common sense: avoid showing off valuables on the street, use rideshare apps instead of hailing taxis off the street, and keep an eye on your belongings in crowded places.

Accommodation

Hotels and Airbnbs near our wedding

We chose as a reference the area between the **Autopista Norte and Carrera Séptima, around Calle 100**: it sits at a comfortable midpoint between the **Parroquia Santa Bibiana** (ceremony) and the **Centro Italiano di Bogotá** (reception), both 15–25 minutes away by car depending on traffic. It's also one of the areas with the most hotels, restaurants, and nightlife in the city — a great base for the rest of your stay.

Tip: search for accommodation on Booking.com or Airbnb filtering for the **Chicó, Zona T, Parque de la 93, Santa Bárbara, or Usaquén** neighborhoods — all of them sit along this corridor and usually have good availability in the USD 85–134 range.

Recommended hotels in the area

Bogotá Plaza Hotel

Cra. 18a #100-41, Usaquén

Classic and very well rated, with breakfast included and spacious rooms. Great value for money and close to restaurants.

Mercure Bogotá Calle 100

Transv. 23 #98-27, Chicó Norte

Comfortable, quiet, and well located right next to a TransMilenio (BRT) station. One of the closest matches to the price range you're looking for.

100 Luxury Suites

Cra. 9a #98-3

Apartment-style suites, ideal if you'd like more space or are traveling as a family. Good value in the area.

NH Collection Bogotá Terra 100 Royal / DoubleTree by Hilton Calle 100

Ac. 100 #19A-70 · Cra. 21 #98-20, Chapinero

A step up in category, with excellent service; the DoubleTree has a pool with mountain views that's well worth it. Ideal if you're after a bit more comfort and don't mind pushing toward the top of the budget.

Bogotá 100 Design Hotel / ESTELAR Calle 100

Ac. 100 #14, near Parque 93

Simpler, more budget-friendly options, very well located for walking to dinner and drinks around Parque 93.

Airbnb

If you'd rather stay in an apartment, look in the **Chicó, El Retiro, Santa Bárbara Occidental, or Usaquén** neighborhoods. There's usually great availability of modern apartments, close to restaurants and a short drive from both wedding venues. We'd suggest booking a couple of months in advance, since November is a busy month for tourism and events in Bogotá.

Keep in mind: prices vary by date and availability — we'd recommend comparing directly on Booking or Airbnb closer to your travel dates to confirm current rates.

Things to do in Bogotá

Our recommendations for getting to know the city

La Candelaria — the historic center

Bogotá's colonial heart: cobblestone streets, colorful houses, and the Gold Museum (Museo del Oro) — an absolute must. Don't miss Plaza de Bolívar, the Botero Museum (free!), and a graffiti tour through the neighborhood — Bogotá's street art scene is internationally renowned.

Monserrate

The mountain that crowns the city, reachable by cable car or funicular. The view of Bogotá from the top is spectacular, especially at sunset, and there's a church and several restaurants once you're up there.

Zona T, Parque de la 93 & Chapinero

The city's go-to area for restaurants, bars, and nightlife. Here you'll find everything from fine dining to some of the best rooftop bars in town — perfect for drinks or a nice dinner with friends.

Usaquén

A charming, colonial-feel neighborhood in the north of the city. On Sundays it hosts a well-loved flea market with handicrafts, street food, and good coffee.

Paloquemao Market

For a more local experience, this market is a great spot to try exotic Colombian fruits (ask for lulo, gulupa, and guanábana!) and a proper Colombian breakfast.

Bonus: if you have time before or after the wedding, a walking free tour through La Candelaria is a great way to get your bearings and learn about the country's history from local guides.

Day trips near Bogotá

Great if you have a free day before or after the wedding

Zipaquirá — Salt Cathedral

Getting there: about 1 hour from Bogotá by car or bus. Regular buses leave from the Portal Norte transit terminal; on weekends, the historic tourist train also runs from the Sabana Station in downtown Bogotá.

A cathedral built inside an active salt mine, with truly impressive architecture carved into the rock. One of the most iconic day trips near the city.

Guatavita

Getting there: about 1.5 hours by car. Public transport is limited, so this is best done with a private driver, rideshare, or a day-tour from Bogotá.

The sacred lagoon of the Muisca people and the origin of the legend of El Dorado. You can do a short guided hike around the lagoon, through a striking páramo (high-altitude moorland) landscape.

Villa de Leyva

Getting there: about 2.5–3 hours by car. Direct buses run from Bogotá's Salitre bus terminal (roughly 3.5 hours).

A beautiful colonial town with one of the largest main squares in South America. Worth staying overnight if you have time — the town and its surroundings (fossils, vineyards, the Pozo Azul lagoon) can easily fill a whole weekend.

Suesca

Getting there: about 1.5 hours by car, or a regional bus from the Portal Norte terminal.

Colombia's most popular rock-climbing destination. If you're the adventurous type, you can also try rappelling and hiking along the canyon of the Bogotá River.

La Calera / Chía

Getting there: 30–45 minutes by car. Easiest by taxi, rideshare, or private tour, since public transport options are limited.

Just outside the city, with lookout points and countryside restaurants overlooking the savanna. In Chía you'll find Andrés Carne de Res, an iconic restaurant-meets-nightclub — a completely different, thoroughly Colombian night out.

A guide across Colombia

If you have extra time, here's our top list of recommendations

Colombia is a big, diverse country — Caribbean coast, mountains, coffee country, Amazon rainforest, and salsa, all in one place. If you're staying longer after the wedding, here are our favorite recommendations by region, including how to get there from Bogotá.

01 Santa Marta & surroundings

Caribbean, jungle, and beach — the gateway to Tayrona

Getting there: about 1h10 by direct flight from Bogotá to Simón Bolívar Airport. The airport is roughly 20 minutes from downtown Santa Marta, and about 45–60 minutes from Tayrona or Palomino by car.

- **Tayrona National Park:** jungle-fringed beaches like Cabo San Juan or Playa Cristal. Entry tickets should be booked ahead, especially in high season.
- **Palomino:** a laid-back beach town, great for river tubing or simply unplugging on the sand.
- **Minca:** up in the Sierra Nevada mountains, with coffee farms, waterfalls, and a much cooler climate than the coast.
- **Ciudad Perdida (Lost City):** a 4–5 day trek to the ruins of an ancient Tayrona city — a more demanding trip, but unforgettable for the adventurous.
- Santa Marta's historic center is also worth a stroll, especially at sunset along the bay.

02 Cartagena

The walled city — color, history, and the Caribbean Sea

Getting there: about 1h15 by direct flight from Bogotá to Rafael Núñez Airport, roughly 15 minutes from the historic walled city.

- **The Walled City & Getsemaní:** wandering aimlessly through its colorful streets is the plan in itself. Getsemaní also has the best nightlife and street art in town.
- **Sunset on the city walls** or from a rooftop bar in the old town — some of the best sunsets on the Caribbean.
- **Islas del Rosario:** a day of beach and snorkeling by boat from Cartagena.
- Try the egg arepas and shrimp ceviche from a street stall — and don't skip a corozo or níspero juice.

03 Coffee Region (Eje Cafetero)

Coffee, mountains, and Colombia's greenest landscapes

Getting there: about 45 minutes by direct flight from Bogotá to Pereira (Matecaña) or Armenia; from either airport, Salento is roughly 40–60 minutes by car. Alternatively, it's a scenic 7–8 hour drive or bus ride from Bogotá.

- **Salento:** a picturesque town with the region's famous colorful facades, ideal as a home base.
- **Valle de Cocora:** a hike among the tallest wax palms in the world (Colombia's national tree!). Easily reached from Salento by a shared Willys jeep.
- **Coffee farm tours:** nearly a must-do — you'll learn the whole process from bean to cup.
- **Filandia:** another beautiful nearby town, with a stunning lookout point over the valley.

04 Medellín

The city of eternal spring

Getting there: about 40 minutes by direct flight from Bogotá to José María Córdova Airport (Rionegro), roughly 45 minutes from the city center. Guatapé is about 2 hours from Medellín by car or bus.

- **Comuna 13:** a graffiti tour and outdoor escalators, telling one of the most striking urban transformation stories in the country.
- **Guatapé & El Peñol:** two hours from Medellín, home to the famous rock (740 steps — worth every one) and the colorful town of Guatapé with its painted "zócalos."
- **Metrocable:** an urban cable car that doubles as public transport and offers stunning views over the city.
- **El Poblado:** the neighborhood for restaurants, specialty coffee shops, and nightlife.

05 Cali

The world capital of salsa

Getting there: about 1 hour by direct flight from Bogotá to Alfonso Bonilla Aragón Airport, roughly 25 minutes from the city center.

- A salsa class or a night out at one of the city's famous salsa clubs ("salsódromos") is a must.
- **Cali Zoo:** considered one of the best in Latin America.
- **Cristo Rey & the San Antonio neighborhood:** lookout points and charming colonial streets.
- If your trip happens to fall in December, the Feria de Cali is a one-of-a-kind experience — though it won't line up with a November wedding.

06 Amazonas

Jungle, river, and indigenous communities — Colombia at its wildest

Getting there: about 2 hours by direct flight from Bogotá to Leticia — the only practical way in, since there are no roads connecting Leticia to the rest of the country (it's only reachable by air or by river).

- **Leticia:** the main gateway, right by the triple border with Brazil and Peru.
- **Puerto Nariño:** a small, car-free town on the Amazon River, a great spot to see pink river dolphins.
- Jungle lodges offer night hikes, piranha fishing, and visits to indigenous communities.
- Remember the yellow fever vaccine if you're planning to visit this region (at least 10 days before travel).



Thank you for coming so far

Your presence is the best gift we could ask for. We hope this guide helps you plan your trip with ease and, hopefully, helps you fall a little in love with Colombia, just like we did.



Questions? Feel free to reach out anytime.

María Paula & Sebastián

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